



▲ THE TIME OF TROUBLES

After Feodor I died childless in 1598, Russia entered a period of disorder called the “time of troubles.” A terrible famine in 1601–1603 killed about one-third of the population, while a series of impostors tried to take the throne, claiming to be Feodor’s half-brother Dmitri. One such “false Dmitri” gathered an army on the edge of Moscow (above) but his planned attack on the city failed.

ROMANOV DYNASTY ►

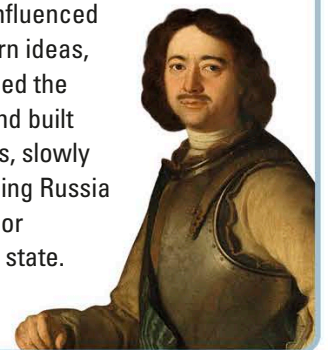
The Romanovs were a family of nobles whose first link to the Russian throne came when a young Romanov woman married Ivan IV in 1547. The Romanovs became the ruling royal family when a reluctant 16-year-old Mikhail Romanov accepted the crown in 1613, starting a new dynasty that was to rule Russia until 1917.



GOLD CROWN
OF MIKHAIL I

PETER THE GREAT

Peter I (reigned 1682–1725) was the first czar to travel widely in western Europe. Influenced by Western ideas, he reformed the military and built new roads, slowly transforming Russia into a major European state.



◀ ST. PETERSBURG

Founded by Peter the Great in 1703, the city of St. Petersburg became the capital of Russia in 1712. The czar intended the city to be a “Window on the West”—a major center for trading with European countries. The city has many fine palaces and beautiful buildings. Like many of these landmarks, the Summer Palace (left) of Empress Elizabeth, daughter of Peter the Great, was built in the Baroque style, then very popular across Europe.